▶ WEST BENGAL

Maachh Fixing?



ALAMY

It must have been during a moment of Zen-like lucidity that a progenitor of the Bengalis coined the phrase '*Maachhe bhaate Bangali*'—to fully soak in that near-spiritual phrase, think something like 'the Bengali soul resides in rice and fish'. Whodathunk in those innocent days that a day would dawn when political piscators would be angling for members of this gentle species while hounding them for their favourite cuisine—in fact, the mainstay for a lot of India, all along its long coastline and all places upriver. When Prime Minister Modi took a dig at Opposition leaders for eating non-vegetarian food during Hindu festivals—doing the usual rally thing from a podium in Udhampur on April 12—his original targets were the Yadav father-son duo Lalu and Tejashwi as well as Rahul Gandhi. The alleged peccancy? Some fried fish Tejashwi had tucked into during Navratri. And a Champaran Mutton that RaGa learnt how to rustle up under Lalu's expert eye last year. At this stage, Modi probably wasn't expecting a riposte from Bengal. But here was a chance to project saffronistas as natural foes of Bengalis...would the Trinamool walk past such a rich repast? Deputy sheriff Abhishek Banerjee fired the first shot, claiming Modi had tagged all Bengalis as 'anti-nationals' for eating fish. The unputdownable Mamata Banerjee was quick on the draw too, telling bemused Jalpaigurians on April 16 that the BJP has an aversion towards fish-eaters. As if political discourse hadn't already turned mustardly enough, a campaign is afoot under the slogan, '*BJP Hatao, Maachh Bhaat Khao* (Oust BJP, Eat Fish-Rice)!' An SFI poster had a plate full of non-vegetarian delicacies, punched with the caption '*Bangali key niramish dekhatey eso na*'—in effect, 'Don't come around trying to vegetarianise Bengalis'. Tejashwi, meanwhile, was seen coolly peeling an orange. Nagpuri, we presume. ■

▶ GUJARAT

EASE OF DOING POLITICS

Gujarat knows how to do its business in a business-like fashion. On April 22, when we hadn't even reached the second round of the Big Bout of 2024, the BJP was already 1-0 up in the next Lok Sabha! This happened when party candidate **Mukesh Dalal** won Surat by technical knockout, getting elected unopposed after the Congress's Nilesh Kumbhani was disqualified, apparently for 'forged signatures' on his nomination papers. A substitute party candidate suffered from the same infirmity. That was not all. The deed was fully accomplished only when, in a synchronised beating the retreat, all the other eight candidates withdrew their nominations on the last day. Meanwhile, even before the Congress could scream "match-fixing" and "traitor", Kumbhani had gone incommunicado, and is reportedly vacationing in Goa with family even as rumours of his flight to the BJP swirled around. But Operation Lotus may have overplayed its hand this time. Indignant Surties took to social media to blast all parties concerned for leaving them "disenfranchised" and demanding criminal action against Kumbhani if he was found to be a willing accomplice in the charade. ■



NIRBHAY KAPADIA

NO CONTEST
Dalal (left) with Gujarat BJP chief C.R. Patil

Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amitabh Srivastava, Jeemon Jacob, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Avishek G. Dastidar and Jumana Shah